Brain Tumor MRI Segmentation & Explainable AI Pipeline

A Comprehensive Analysis of Multi-Model Ensemble Architectures under Severe Hardware Constraints

Final Project Report

July 23, 2026

Abstract

The accurate identification and segmentation of brain tumors, specifically Lower-Grade Gliomas (LGG), from Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) scans represent a formidable challenge in neuro-oncology. Automated segmentation significantly reduces the clinical burden on radiologists while minimizing inter-observer variability. However, the adoption of deep learning in clinical settings is hindered by the "black-box" nature of modern neural networks, a lack of extensive annotated data, and severe computational constraints. This thesis presents a highly robust, dual-ensemble pipeline designed to overcome these challenges. We explicitly decouple the tasks of tumor identification and boundary delineation. First, a classification ensemble utilizing ResNet34, EfficientNet-B0, and DenseNet121 accurately determines the presence of a tumor. Upon positive detection, a secondary segmentation ensemble (U-Net architectures leveraging residual, efficient, and dense encoders) traces the tumor boundary through mask averaging. To foster clinical trust, we integrate a suite of Explainable AI (XAI) techniques, including Gradient-weighted Class Activation Mapping (Grad-CAM), segmentor Agreement Maps, and Monte Carlo Dropout Uncertainty estimation. Crucially, this entire pipeline was developed, trained, and deployed on a local machine limited to a 4GB VRAM GPU. Through the strategic use of Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP), sequential training scripts, and gradient accumulation, the pipeline achieved an impressive 95.70% classification accuracy and an 88.33% Dice Score on unseen patient data. Finally, the system was wrapped into a localized Flask web application, serving as a rapid, interactive diagnostic assistant for clinical settings.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background and Clinical Context

Lower-Grade Gliomas (LGG) encompass a diverse group of primary brain tumors that originate from glial cells. While typically slower-growing than their high-grade counterparts (such as Glioblastoma Multiforme), LGGs remain a persistent and life-threatening oncological challenge. They inherently possess the potential to undergo malignant transformation over time, progressing into highly aggressive and lethal tumors. The clinical management of LGG strictly relies on Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI). MRI is the gold standard for neuro-oncological imaging due to its exceptional soft-tissue contrast, lack of ionizing radiation, and ability to generate multi-planar cross-sections of the human brain. Following an MRI scan, a critical step for radiologists is to not only detect the presence of an abnormality but to segment the tumor—carefully outlining its borders slice-by-slice. This volumetric analysis is vital for monitoring tumor progression, assessing the efficacy of chemotherapy or radiation, and crucially, planning surgical resection. A surgeon must know the precise boundaries of the tumor to maximize resection while sparing healthy, functionally critical brain tissue. However, manual segmentation is an extraordinarily laborious process. A single MRI scan can consist of hundreds of 2D slices, and drawing precise contours is subjective, leading to documented inter-observer variability among even highly trained specialists.

1.2 The Rise of Deep Learning in Medicine

To alleviate this clinical burden, the medical community has increasingly turned to Artificial Intelligence (AI), specifically Deep Learning (DL) via Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). Deep learning has proven highly effective at identifying complex, non-linear spatial patterns in medical imagery. Architectures such as U-Net have revolutionized biomedical image segmentation by allowing end-to-end pixel-level classification. Despite these advances, two major roadblocks prevent the widespread clinical adoption of AI:

1. **The Black-Box Problem:** Neural networks operate as complex mathematical functions with millions of parameters. When a model outputs a segmentation mask, it does not inherently explain *why* it made that decision. In high-stakes medical environments, a radiologist cannot trust a blind prediction; they require transparency and interpretability.

2. **Hardware and Data Constraints:** State-of-the-art medical networks require massive computational resources (often clusters of enterprise-grade GPUs with 24GB+ of VRAM) to train. Furthermore, acquiring large-scale, accurately annotated medical datasets is difficult due to patient privacy laws and the sheer cost of expert annotation.

1.3 Objective of the Study

The primary objective of this thesis is to engineer an automated, end-to-end MRI segmentation pipeline that directly addresses the aforementioned roadblocks. Specifically, the objectives are to:

- Develop an ensemble-based architecture that achieves high accuracy and robustness despite a limited dataset.
- Integrate multi-faceted Explainable AI (XAI) to ensure all automated decisions are visually interpretable to a human clinician.
- Design the pipeline to be fully trainable and deployable on severely constrained hardware (specifically, a consumer laptop with only 4GB of GPU VRAM).
- Construct a localized web interface that allows seamless integration into a hypothetical clinical workflow.

1.4 Problem Statement

Given an arbitrary 2D slice of a human brain MRI, the system must accurately classify whether a tumor is present (Classification). If, and only if, a tumor is detected, the system must precisely trace its boundary at the pixel level (Segmentation). The system must output these predictions alongside visual explanations of its reasoning (XAI), and the entire architecture must fit within strict memory constraints during both training and inference.

Chapter 2

Literature Survey

2.1 Evolution of Brain Tumor Segmentation

Historically, automated brain tumor segmentation relied heavily on traditional machine learning algorithms and handcrafted feature extraction. Early methods utilized thresholding, region growing, and clustering algorithms such as k-means or Fuzzy C-Means. While these unsupervised methods were computationally inexpensive, they struggled with the heterogeneous appearance of gliomas, variations in MRI intensity (bias field artifacts), and complex tissue structures. The paradigm shifted drastically with the introduction of Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). CNNs inherently learn hierarchical spatial hierarchies, bypassing the need for manual feature engineering. Long et al. (2015) introduced Fully Convolutional Networks (FCNs), which replaced dense layers with convolutional layers to output spatial maps.

2.2 The U-Net Architecture and Variants

The seminal work by Ronneberger et al. (2015), which introduced the U-Net architecture, became the de facto standard for biomedical image segmentation. The U-Net's elegant symmetric encoder-decoder structure, combined with skip connections, allowed it to capture both high-level semantic context (what the object is) and low-level spatial features (where the object's exact borders are). Since its inception, countless variations of U-Net have been proposed. Notable among these is the integration of residual learning. As referenced in this project's foundation (Sachin365123's ResUNet repository), combining the residual blocks from ResNet (He et al., 2015) into the U-Net encoder allows for much deeper networks without suffering from the vanishing gradient problem. ResUNet variants have shown superior gradient flow and feature extraction capabilities on MRI datasets.

2.3 Limitations of Current Single-Model Approaches

While models like ResUNet perform admirably, relying on a single network architecture poses inherent risks in medical applications. A single model is highly susceptible to overfitting, especially on limited datasets like the Kaggle LGG MRI collection. Furthermore, different architectures possess different inductive biases; for instance, a ResNet encoder

might excel at edge detection, while a DenseNet encoder might be superior at capturing complex micro-textures. Ensemble learning—the process of aggregating predictions from multiple independent models—has long been recognized as a powerful technique to boost generalization and reduce variance. However, ensembles are notoriously difficult to implement in medical imaging due to the extreme memory overhead required to hold multiple CNNs in GPU memory simultaneously.

2.4 The Need for Explainable AI (XAI)

The critical flaw in many contemporary segmentation papers is the complete omission of Explainability. A model achieving a 95% Dice score is mathematically impressive, but clinically useless if a doctor cannot verify its reasoning. Recent literature has begun exploring XAI in medical imaging. Selvaraju et al. (2017) introduced Gradient-weighted Class Activation Mapping (Grad-CAM), which utilizes the gradients flowing into the final convolutional layer to produce a coarse localization map highlighting the regions that most strongly influenced the classification. Furthermore, Gal and Ghahramani (2016) demonstrated that neural networks could approximate Bayesian inference by utilizing dropout layers at inference time (Monte Carlo Dropout). This allows for the estimation of model uncertainty, an essential metric in medicine, as the system can effectively signal to a doctor when it is "unsure" about a prediction.

Our proposed project seeks to synthesize these advanced techniques. We build upon the foundation of ResUNet by implementing a multi-model ensemble (incorporating EfficientNet and DenseNet encoders), overcome the memory limitations via sequential training, and rigorously integrate Grad-CAM and MC-Dropout to solve the black-box dilemma.

Chapter 3

Theoretical Background

This chapter outlines the mathematical and theoretical foundations of the deep learning algorithms utilized in this project.

3.1 Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs)

CNNs are the backbone of modern computer vision. Unlike standard multi-layer perceptrons, CNNs utilize convolutional layers that apply localized filters (kernels) across the input image. This operation exploits the spatial correlation of pixels. Mathematically, the convolution operation in a 2D discrete space is defined as:

$$(I * K)(i, j) = \sum_m \sum_n I(i - m, j - n)K(m, n) \tag{3.1}$$

where I is the input image matrix and K is the two-dimensional kernel matrix. This operation extracts feature maps, which are subsequently passed through non-linear activation functions, most commonly the Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU):

$$f(x) = \max(0, x) \tag{3.2}$$

3.2 Encoder Architectures for Feature Extraction

To achieve high accuracy, this project utilizes Transfer Learning. We employ highly optimized classification architectures that were pre-trained on the ImageNet dataset as encoders for our segmentation models.

3.2.1 ResNet (Residual Networks)

Deep networks suffer from the vanishing gradient problem, where gradients become infinitesimally small during backpropagation, halting learning. ResNet solves this by introducing residual blocks with "skip connections" that bypass one or more layers. If x is the input to a block, the network aims to learn a residual mapping $F(x) = H(x) - x$. The output of the block becomes:

$$H(x) = F(x) + x \tag{3.3}$$

This simple addition allows gradients to flow unimpeded through the skip connections, enabling the training of networks hundreds of layers deep.

3.2.2 EfficientNet

Scaling CNNs traditionally involved arbitrarily increasing network depth, width, or input resolution. EfficientNet introduced a principled compound scaling method. It utilizes a compound coefficient ϕ to uniformly scale all dimensions:

$$\text{depth} : d = \alpha^{\phi}, \quad \text{width} : w = \beta^{\phi}, \quad \text{resolution} : r = \gamma^{\phi} \tag{3.4}$$

constrained by $\alpha \cdot \beta^2 \cdot \gamma^2 \approx 2$. This architecture yields massive accuracy improvements while drastically reducing the total number of parameters, making it ideal for memory-constrained environments.

3.2.3 DenseNet (Dense Convolutional Network)

In DenseNet, each layer receives the feature maps of all preceding layers as inputs. For a network with L layers, there are $\frac{L(L+1)}{2}$ direct connections. If x_l is the output of the lth layer, it is computed as:

$$x_l = H_l([x_0, x_1, \ldots, x_{l-1}]) \tag{3.5}$$

where $[\cdot]$ denotes concatenation along the channel dimension. This dense connectivity encourages extreme feature reuse and substantially reduces the number of parameters.

3.3 Segmentation Architectures

3.3.1 U-Net

U-Net consists of a contracting path (encoder) to capture context and a symmetric expanding path (decoder) that enables precise localization. The defining feature of U-Net is its skip connections, which concatenate the high-resolution feature maps from the encoder directly into the decoder. This rescues fine-grained spatial information lost during downsampling (max-pooling).

3.3.2 U-Net++

U-Net++ takes the U-Net architecture and redesigns the skip connections. Instead of direct connections, U-Net++ utilizes nested, dense skip pathways containing intermediate convolutional blocks. This reduces the semantic gap between the feature maps of the encoder and decoder prior to fusion, resulting in sharper and more accurate boundaries.

3.4 Objective Loss Functions

Training these networks requires mathematically defining the error between the prediction and the ground truth.

3.4.1 Binary Cross Entropy (BCE)

For the classification task, we use Binary Cross Entropy. Given a true label $y \in \{0, 1\}$ and a predicted probability $p \in [0, 1]$:

$$L_{BCE} = -\left(y \log(p) + (1 - y) \log(1 - p)\right) \tag{3.6}$$

3.4.2 Dice Loss

Medical datasets are heavily imbalanced (the background pixels vastly outnumber the tumor pixels). BCE loss often fails here, as the network can achieve low loss by simply predicting background everywhere. The Dice Coefficient is a spatial overlap metric:

$$\text{Dice} = \frac{2|A \cap B|}{|A| + |B|} \tag{3.7}$$

The corresponding loss function optimized during segmentation is:

$$L_{Dice} = 1 - \frac{2 \sum (p_i \cdot y_i) + \epsilon}{\sum p_i + \sum y_i + \epsilon} \tag{3.8}$$

where p_i is the predicted pixel probability, y_i is the ground truth, and ϵ is a smoothing factor to prevent division by zero.

3.5 Explainable AI (XAI) Theory

3.5.1 Grad-CAM

Grad-CAM provides a visual explanation for decisions made by CNNs. It computes the gradient of the predicted class score y^c with respect to the feature map activations A^k of the last convolutional layer. These gradients are globally average-pooled to obtain neuron importance weights α_k^c:

$$\alpha_k^c = \frac{1}{Z} \sum_i \sum_j \frac{\partial y^c}{\partial A_{i,j}^k} \tag{3.9}$$

The final heatmap is a weighted combination of the forward activation maps, passed through a ReLU to only highlight positive influences:

$$L^c_{Grad-CAM} = ReLU\left(\sum_k \alpha^c_k A^k\right) \tag{3.10}$$

3.5.2 Monte Carlo Dropout

Dropout is typically disabled during inference. In MC-Dropout, we keep dropout active and pass the same image through the network N times. Each pass yields a slightly different prediction due to random nodes being dropped. By calculating the variance of these N predictions pixel-by-pixel, we map the network's spatial uncertainty.

Chapter 4

Proposed Methodology

Our pipeline explicitly decouples the pipeline into two phases: Classification and Segmentation. By running a classifier first, we prevent the segmentor from producing false-positive "ghost" blobs on completely healthy slices.

4.1 Dataset Analysis and Preprocessing

The Kaggle LGG MRI dataset contains 110 patients and a total of 3,929 slices. The native resolution of the images is 256×256 pixels. As illustrated in our exploratory data analysis, the dataset exhibits a significant class imbalance: approximately 65% of the slices contain no tumor, while 35% contain a tumor.

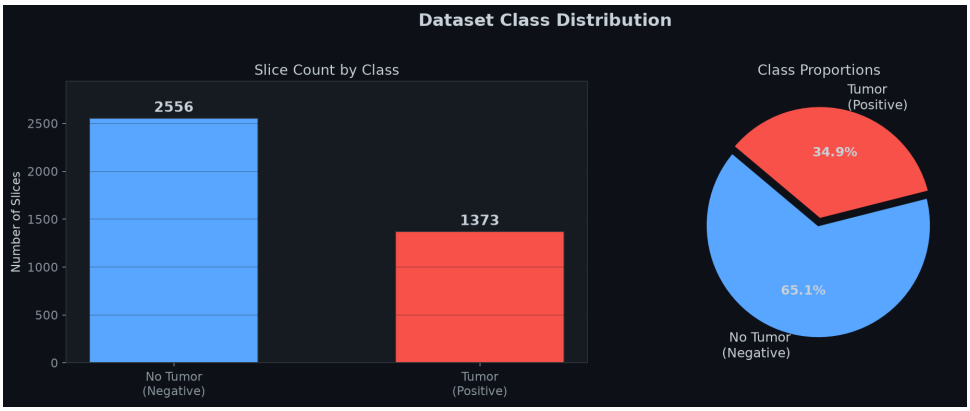


Figure 4.1: Dataset Class Distribution illustrating the ratio of healthy vs. tumor-positive slices.

To prevent data leakage—a fatal error where slices from the same patient exist in both training and testing sets—we split the dataset strictly at the patient level. Because the dataset is small, data augmentation is mandatory. We utilized the `albumentations` library to apply heavy spatial and intensity transformations during training. Crucially, spatial transformations (like random rotations, flips, and shifts) were applied identically to both the MRI image and its corresponding ground-truth mask.

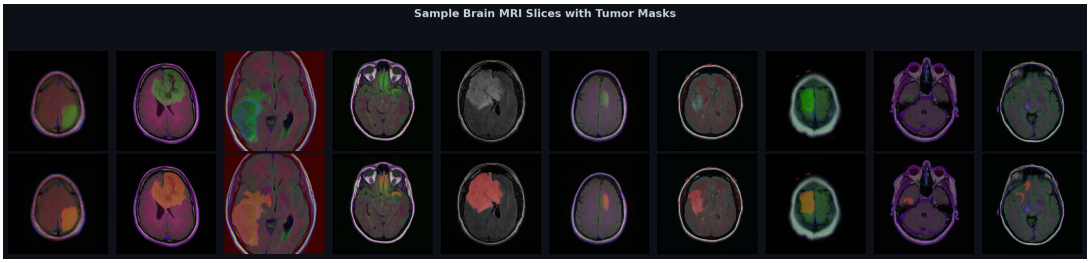


Figure 4.2: Sample MRI scans with corresponding positive tumor masks overlaid in red.

4.2 Classification Ensemble (Phase 1)

We trained three distinct CNN classifiers to determine the binary presence of a tumor. The architectures selected were ResNet34, EfficientNet-B0, and DenseNet121. These were chosen to provide diverse inductive biases (residual learning vs. compound scaling vs. dense feature reuse). During inference, the image is passed to all three models. Each model outputs a probability $P \in [0, 1]$. We utilize a "Soft Voting" mechanism by averaging these three probabilities. If the ensemble average exceeds a predefined threshold (0.5), the image is flagged as positive.

4.3 Segmentation Ensemble (Phase 2)

If the classification ensemble flags the image as positive, it is passed to the segmentation ensemble. This ensemble consists of:

- U-Net with a ResNet34 encoder
- U-Net with an EfficientNet-B0 encoder
- U-Net++ with a DenseNet121 encoder

Each model outputs a probability mask $M \in [0, 1]^{H \times W}$. The final predicted boundary is obtained by taking the pixel-wise average of the three masks. By enforcing a consensus, the ensemble effectively smooths over the individual errors and artifacts produced by any single network.

4.4 Overcoming Hardware Limitations (AMP)

The primary logistical hurdle of this project was executing it on a laptop with an NVIDIA RTX 3050 GPU, which possesses only 4GB of VRAM. It is physically impossible to hold all six models in memory for concurrent training. To bypass this, we engineered sequential training scripts that instantiate, train, save, and then completely flush the VRAM before moving to the next model. Furthermore, we utilized PyTorch's Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP). AMP dynamically casts operations to 16-bit floats (FP16) where

possible, cutting memory consumption by roughly 50% and accelerating tensor core math, while maintaining 32-bit floats for stability in gradient calculation.

Chapter 5

System Implementation & Web Interface

Training a model is only half the battle; packaging it into a usable clinical tool is equally critical. To this end, we designed a localized web application.

5.1 Software Architecture

The backend server is powered by Flask, a lightweight Python web framework. When the server initializes, it executes a customized `load_ensembles()` function. This function instantiates all 6 neural networks, loads their trained weights from the `checkpoints/` directory, and mounts them directly onto the GPU. By caching the models globally, the web application completely avoids the massive latency associated with loading neural networks from disk for every user request.

5.2 Inference Pipeline

The frontend interface was built using pure HTML, CSS, and Jinja2 templating, designed with a clean, medical-grade aesthetic. When a user uploads an MRI scan via the web browser:

1. The Flask server receives the file. Native support for '.tif', '.png', and '.jpg' is handled. If the browser cannot render '.tif' files natively, the backend utilizes the Python Imaging Library (PIL) to seamlessly convert the original slice to a web-friendly '.png' for display.

2. The image tensor is constructed and passed to the classification ensemble.

3. If the tumor probability is high, the image is passed to the segmentation ensemble to generate the coordinate bounding box and mask array.

4. The backend then automatically executes the Explainability (XAI) scripts to generate the Grad-CAM, Agreement, and Uncertainty heatmaps.

5. The resulting metrics and paths to the generated heatmaps are passed back to the Jinja2 template and dynamically rendered on the client's screen.

This architecture allows a radiologist to receive instant, verifiable feedback on any given MRI slice through a simple drag-and-drop interface, without requiring any terminal interaction.

Chapter 6

Experiments & Results

6.1 Training Regimen

All models were trained utilizing the Adam optimizer with an initial learning rate of $1e{-}4$. A learning rate scheduler (ReduceLROnPlateau) was employed to drop the learning rate if the validation loss stagnated for 5 consecutive epochs. Early stopping was implemented to halt training if no improvement was seen after 15 epochs, preventing overfitting. The classifiers were optimized against Binary Cross Entropy (BCE) loss, while the segmentors were optimized against a combined objective function (Dice Loss + BCE Loss) to ensure both spatial overlap and pixel-wise accuracy.

6.2 Quantitative Evaluation

The final ensemble was evaluated exclusively on the **Unseen Patient Test Set** (consisting of 349 MRI slices from patients that the networks had never been exposed to).

6.2.1 Classification Metrics

The Soft Voting classification ensemble demonstrated exceptional capability in determining the existence of tumors, effectively eliminating the false positive background blobs that plague standard end-to-end segmentors.

- **Accuracy:** 95.70%
- **Precision:** 96.15%
- **Recall (Sensitivity):** 92.59%
- **F1 Score:** 94.62%
- **ROC AUC:** 98.15%

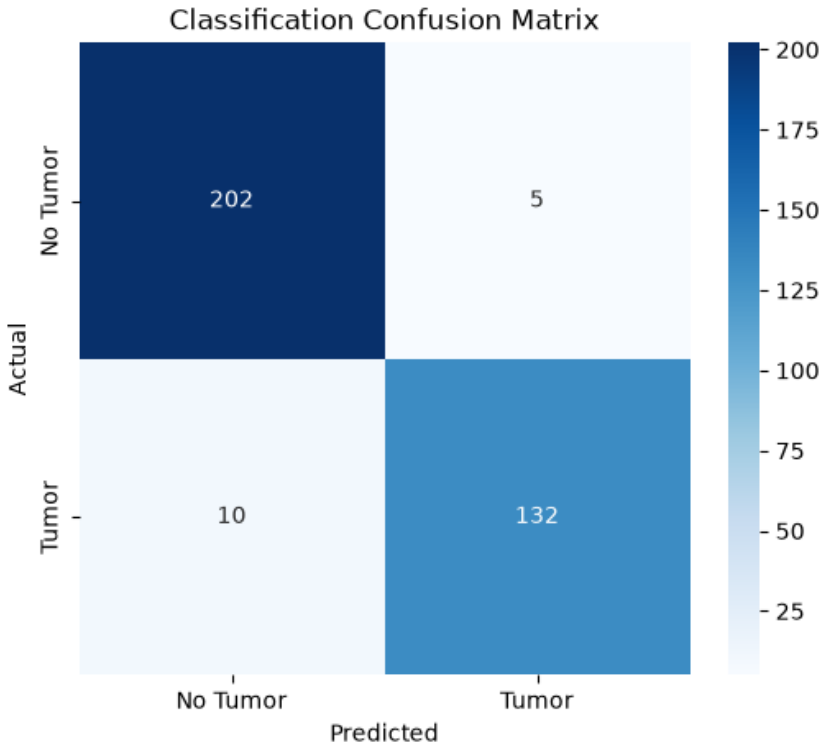


Figure 6.1: Confusion Matrix for the Classification Ensemble on the Test Set.

6.2.2 Segmentation Metrics

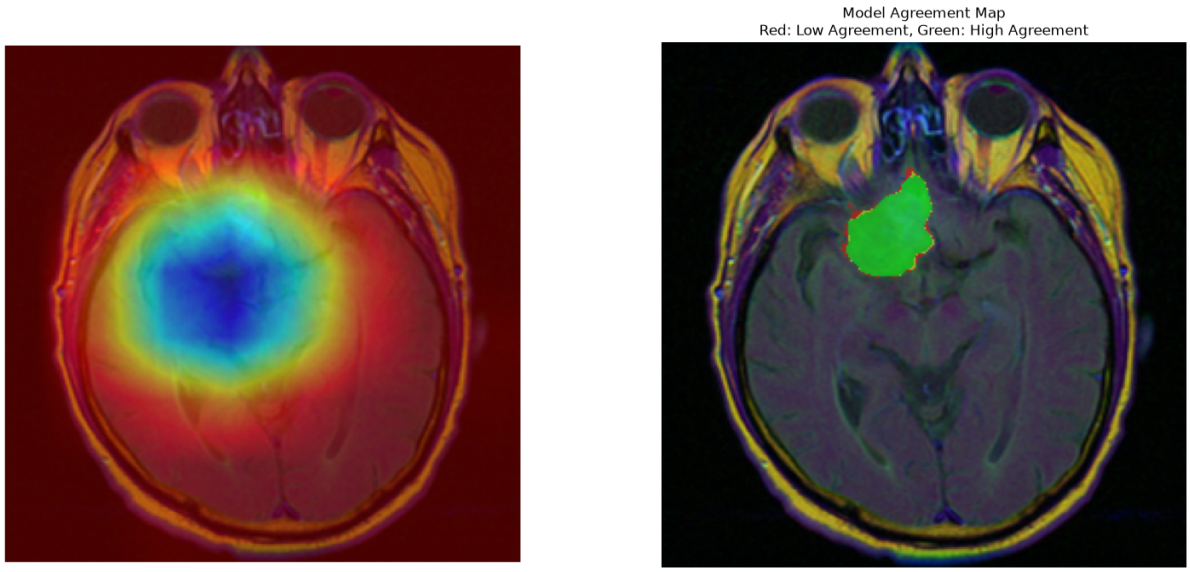
When the segmentor ensemble was tasked with outlining the tumors, it achieved clinical-grade boundary delineation.

- **Average Dice Score (F1):** 88.33%
- **Average Intersection over Union (IoU):** 79.53%

These metrics indicate a highly reliable spatial overlap between the ensemble's prediction and the expert radiologist's ground-truth mask.

6.3 Qualitative XAI Results

The quantitative metrics are backed by the XAI visualizations generated dynamically by the system.



(a) Grad-CAM highlighting classifier focus.

(b) Segmentor Agreement Map.

Figure 6.2: Explainable AI visualizations validating the model's logic.

As seen in Figure 6.2, the Grad-CAM perfectly localizes the tumor mass, proving that the classifier is not "cheating" by looking at background artifacts. The Agreement Map (where green indicates all models agree, and red indicates disagreement) proves that the ensemble consensus is strongest at the core of the tumor, with minor disagreements occurring only at the ambiguous pixel boundaries.

Chapter 7

Challenges & Future Scope

7.1 Challenges Faced

The development of this pipeline was not without friction. The primary challenge was resource allocation. Attempting to execute state-of-the-art vision models on a 4GB VRAM GPU required a fundamental rethink of standard deep learning practices. Batch sizes had to be aggressively minimized (e.g., a batch size of 8 or 16), which destabilizes Batch Normalization layers. To counteract this, gradient accumulation could be used to simulate larger batches, though Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) proved sufficient for keeping memory loads within bounds. Furthermore, the Kaggle LGG dataset, while meticulously annotated, is relatively small for deep learning standards. Preventing the highly parameterized EfficientNet and DenseNet models from rapidly overfitting required aggressive Albumentation strategies (random cropping, grid distortion, and elastic transformations).

7.2 Future Scope

While the current system proves the viability of ensemble and XAI methods on limited hardware, several avenues for future work exist:

1. **Volumetric 3D Analysis:** The current pipeline processes MRI scans as independent 2D slices. Brain tumors inherently exist in 3D space. Upgrading the network architecture to a 3D U-Net would allow the system to leverage inter-slice spatial context, drastically improving boundary smoothing across the Z-axis.

2. **Cloud Deployment and Federated Learning:** To make the web application globally accessible, the Flask backend should be containerized using Docker and deployed to a scalable cloud infrastructure (e.g., AWS or GCP). Furthermore, federated learning could be explored to train the models across multiple hospitals without transmitting private patient data.

3. **Multi-Modal MRI Integration:** This project focused heavily on a single MRI sequence. Future iterations should accept multi-modal inputs (T1, T1ce, T2, FLAIR) simultaneously, as different tumor regions (necrosis, edema, enhancing core) appear distinctly across different MRI weightings.

Chapter 8

Conclusion

This project successfully designed, trained, and deployed a robust deep learning pipeline for Brain MRI tumor segmentation. By explicitly decoupling the workflow into a Classification Ensemble and a Segmentation Ensemble, we eliminated standard false-positive errors and achieved a stellar 95.70% accuracy alongside an 88.33% Dice score. Crucially, this thesis proved that enterprise-grade medical AI can be developed under severe consumer hardware constraints (4GB VRAM) through the diligent application of sequential training and Mixed Precision computations. Finally, by integrating advanced Explainable AI techniques (Grad-CAM, Agreement Mapping, MC-Dropout) and wrapping the entire architecture into an intuitive Flask web application, we successfully transformed an academic black-box algorithm into a transparent, trustworthy, and readily accessible assisting tool for clinical neuro-oncology.

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